

THE COURSE OF THE WAR

At the beginning of the war, the Germans' progress seemed unstoppable, until a harsh winter and fierce resistance halted them in Russia. When the USA joined the war at the end of 1941, the tide turned. The Allies won victories in North Africa and the Pacific, then, in 1944, they landed in France and began to take back Europe.

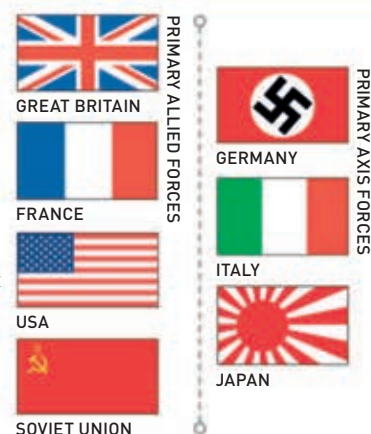


World War II

In September 1939 Germany, led by dictator Adolf Hitler, invaded Poland and triggered World War II, the deadliest conflict in history. By the end of the war six years later, around 60 million people had been killed, more than half of them civilians. A large part of Europe was in ruins, and two Japanese cities had been obliterated by nuclear bombs.

AXIS vs ALLIES

The Axis alliance was formed in 1939 by Germany and Italy. In 1940 Japan joined and the countries formed the Tripartite Pact. The original members of the Allies were Britain and France, until 1940 when Germany invaded France and the French government was exiled to London. In 1941 the Soviet Union and the USA joined the Allies. In 1943 Italy surrendered, then changed sides to fight on the side of the Allies.



THEATRES OF WAR

For the first two years of the war, fighting raged across Western Europe, on the Eastern Front in Russia, and in North Africa. By the end of 1941, when the USA and Japan joined in, the conflict had spread to the Pacific and Southeast Asia. Few nations were able to stay neutral as war engulfed the whole world.



THE WAR IN EUROPE, NORTH AFRICA, AND THE MEDITERRANEAN

Germany began the war with the upper hand, rampaging through Europe and taking over a series of countries. Gradually, the Allies pushed back, and by 1943 Germany was in retreat.

KEY

- Allied areas
- Allied-occupied areas
- Axis countries
- Axis-occupied areas
- Axis allies
- Neutral countries



THE WAR IN THE PACIFIC AND ASIA

Japan joined the Axis countries in 1941 and quickly overran much of Southeast Asia, including Malaya and Singapore. The Allies fought back on land and sea, but it was superior airpower – and the dropping of two atomic bombs – that led to the Allies' victory.

KEY

- Allied areas
- Axis countries
- Axis-occupied areas
- Axis allies
- Limit of Japanese advance

AIR POWER

World War II was the first war in which fighting took place as much in the air as on land or sea. There were three main types of planes: fighters, bombers, and transport planes.



SMALL ARMS

Technology played a crucial role in the war, with both sides competing to produce weapons more efficient and deadlier than ever before. Rifles, machine-guns, mortars, and hand grenades were all improved during the course of the war.



FIGHTING MEN

In most countries men were conscripted during the war, meaning they had to join the armed forces. Only those doing certain jobs, such as miners or farmers, or people in poor health were not required to join up.

